

This guide can be used by staff and administrators at institutions of higher education to develop procedures for collecting data on the outcomes of students with intellectual disability after they graduate from higher education programs.

Why Collect Outcome Data?

Outcomes are an important piece in the evaluation process. There are several important reasons to track student outcomes, including:

- » to provide evidence of student success,
- » to track trends in the student outcomes over time, and
- » to identify areas in which improvements can be made in the program.

Outcome data are also important to prospective students and families. They will want to understand the likely benefits of your program in terms of post-program opportunities, such as employment, independent living, and community engagement. Outcome data also provide evidence of student success that can be used to market and advocate for your program.

In this guide, we provide suggestions and examples of outcome data collection tools and procedures for collecting data from former students.

Tools for Collecting Outcome Data

What is being measured?

An initial step in the outcome data process is to determine the questions that you want to ask former students. A few key areas to consider are employment, further education, independent living, and quality of life. These outcomes are measured in larger datasets such as the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID) model demonstration program, the National Longitudinal Transition Study-2 (NLTS2) and NLTS 2012, National Core Indicators (NCI), and RSA-911.

Aligning your program's outcome data collection tool with any or all of these larger datasets will enable you to compare student outcome data from your college program with national data. See Table 1 for details about each dataset.

Table 1: Comparison Data Sources

Data Source	Who
TPSID model demonstration program (U.S. Department of Education, Office of Postsecondary Education)	Students with intellectual disability attending federally funded higher education programs.
NLTS2 & NLTS 2012 (U.S. Department of Education & Office of Special Programs)	Longitudinal study of 15,000 students' experiences from 400 school districts, ages 13 to 21, around transition to college, training, employment, and independent living.
National Core Indicators (National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services & Human Services Research Institute)	Service outcomes of individuals with developmental disabilities across numerous states around areas of employment, service planning, community inclusion, health, safety, etc.
RSA-911 (Office of Special Education and Rehabilitative Services)	Individuals with disabilities who receive services from vocational rehabilitation increasing their access to employment, independence, and community integration.

The next step is to decide whether to create a new outcome data tool or select/modify an existing tool. In the sections below, we provide examples of two outcome data surveys: the TPSID outcome data survey, used to gather data on students who have completed TPSID programs across the country, and the University Participant (UP) Program data collection survey, used to gather data on students who complete the UP Program at Western Carolina University.

TPSID outcome data survey

The Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID) model demonstration program provides federally funded grants to colleges and universities for developing or enhancing postsecondary education programs for students with intellectual disability. More than 50 colleges and universities are implementing TPSID projects between 2015 and 2020.

The National Coordinating Center (NCC) for the TPSID projects is charged with development and implementation of a valid framework to evaluate the TPSID program, including reporting the outcomes of students who attend TPSID programs. The outcome data survey is one piece of the broad evaluation tool that was developed in alignment with the Think College Standards for Inclusive Higher Education and approved by the Office of Management and Budget (Grigal, Hart, & Weir, 2011).

For more information in the TPSID model demonstration program, see: <https://thinkcollege.net/tpsid>

The TPSID outcome data survey is administered annually to all students who completed TPSID programs. The survey has 18 questions across the areas of work, education, independent living, and quality of life. Some of the questions are aligned with other data collected from TPSIDs while students are in the program so that comparisons can be made with students' experiences while they were in college.

The TPSID outcome data survey consists mainly of checkbox and multiple-choice items. The number of open-ended qualitative questions is limited due to the challenge of collecting and analyzing data from a large number of programs and students. However, you may find it useful to include more open-ended responses or to gather stories of what students have been doing since completing your program.

The most important questions are asked first. Questions about work are on the first page since that is a highly desired outcome for students, and it is important to make sure employment information is collected from all respondents. Some students have more than one job, so employment-related questions ask them to consider the job where they spend the most time (in other words, their primary employer).

The next questions are about further education. There is a subtle difference in language between the employment question and the education question. The employment

question asks, "Do you have a paid job now?" whereas the education question asks, "In the last year, have you taken any classes at a college, university or vocational/technical school?" Asking people if they are taking college classes now can lead to misleading answers. For example, if the question is asked during summer break, a student may answer no even if they completed coursework during the spring semester. Asking if they have taken a class in the past year gives a better idea of whether or not they have gone on to any further education. This also aligns with how these questions are asked in the NLTS2 survey.

The remaining questions in the TPSID data collection survey ask about unpaid work, satisfaction with social life, living situation, and receipt of benefits (e.g., social security, unemployment, health insurance). The survey was revised in 2018 to reduce the amount of time needed to complete it while retaining the most important questions.

UP Program data collection survey

The University Participant (UP) Program at Western Carolina University provides a two-year, on-campus living and learning experience for college-age people with intellectual disability. During the two-year period, students are expected to complete requirements for receiving a UP Certificate of Accomplishment based on the successful completion of an Individual Plan for College Participation.

The UP Certificate of Accomplishment is awarded after a two-year period based on satisfactory completion of five program components: personal development skills, community participation skills, vocational preparation skills, social participation and learning, and course auditing.

For more information on the UP Program, see: www.wcu.edu/learn/departments-schools-colleges/ceap/stl/special-education-programs/university-participant-up-program/

Staff at the UP Program realized that collecting post-program student data would help inform student and program practices by cohort. Analyzing outcomes in this way allows program staff to review data and determine what is working and where improvements could be made. Questions in the UP survey parallel language from NLTS2 to provide a source for comparison data. The survey was piloted with a small number of students and their families to ensure that it was understandable, free of jargon, and easily navigated.

The UP survey first asks about employment outcomes since leaving the program, because paid community employment

is a desired outcome for all students who attend this program. Employment is defined clearly as “meaningful employment at minimum wage or above.”

The survey asks students about numerous aspects of work, including:

- » Number of hours worked (for UP, 20 hours or more per week = meaningful employment)
- » What kind of paid jobs and number of jobs (this helps identify if having more jobs during the program leads to long-term, meaningful employment)
- » If any special commendations or promotions been earned (this helps UP staff see if any skills learned have helped with job retention)
- » If the former student has been fired or laid off (this can help inform whether UP needs to emphasize certain skills more heavily)
- » If they are currently employed and in what field

The next section of questions in the UP survey asks about living arrangements and community activities. This helps to identify if former students have good quality of life and meaningful daily routines. The questions in this section focus on the level of independent living and how often former students participate in activities outside of the home. Since UP is located in a rural setting, outcome data can show isolation compared to more urban or suburban college campuses. However, some UP students in the last 12 years have received their driver’s license, and that has helped increase their overall community involvement.

There are also questions about financial skills, supports, and services. The UP Program teaches some financial skills, so asking these questions helps determine if students use those skills after completion of the program, such as maintaining a savings or checking account, using and paying off the balance on a credit card, or paying other bills. The supports and services question includes more than 20 options of

Table 2: Sample Outcome Survey Questions

Outcome Area	Sample Questions
Employment	• What is the minimum number of hours per week you worked on a job since leaving the program? What is the maximum? • What is the longest amount of time you have maintained employment on a paid job in the community after leaving the program? • How much do you get paid? • Do you receive benefits from your employment? • What is the total number of jobs (part - time or full - time) you have held since completing the program? This includes multiple jobs held at once or consecutively. • In any of the jobs held, were you promoted or assigned to take on more responsibilities than at the beginning of the job? Please explain. • Have you participated in volunteer or unpaid internship work?
Independent Living and Social Life	• How satisfied are you with your social life? • Where do you live now? • Who do you live with? • Do you have a significant other? • How do you travel around community? • How do you spend your leisure time?
Other	• Do you receive SSI, SSDI, unemployment, other, benefits? • Do you have health insurance? • What financial skills do you have? • In the last year, have you taken any classes at college, university, or vocational school? Did you earn a degree? If so, from what school?

services a former student may be accessing, and helps identify how involved community agencies are in supporting students after they leave the college program.

Social skills are very important, so questions are asked to identify the types of relationships students have after college: How are students spending leisure time? What do they do when they're not at work or involved in community activities? Do they travel, visit friends or family, volunteer, engage in hobbies? All of these additional activities contribute to a well-rounded life. Former students or their families are allowed (and encouraged) to provide answers or input in this final question. This qualitative information can be helpful to guide program improvement, and student success stories can be used for advocacy and marketing.

The TPSID and UP Program surveys have many similar questions. Table 2 lists sample outcome survey questions that are common to both data collection tools. You can use these questions as the starting point for developing your own outcome survey.

How to Collect Data

Once you have designed or selected your questions, you'll need to think about how you will collect data. You could conduct a phone survey in which you call graduates and ask them the questions, mail out a paper survey, or share the link to an electronic survey via email, text, or another messaging platform.

For the TPSID data collection, all of these options are offered, and program staff can decide what works best for them. For the UP Program, students and families can report outcome data after completion via phone or through an online survey.

The TPSID survey begins with asking for updated contact information so that program staff can keep in touch with the student. The NCC is not permitted to receive identifying information on students, and TPSID programs are responsible for maintaining up-to-date contact information for former students. It is important to work with your institution in identifying who is responsible for maintaining the database of contact information on former students.

Make sure to gather information about who is completing your survey. Students and families may choose to complete the phone interviews or online surveys together or separately. Some students choose to live and work with friends or support people they met in college rather than living near family members after program completion, so

those additional support people may be involved in survey completion as well.

Your university may require institutional review board, or IRB, approval of your survey mechanism and content. You should consider adding a consent page to your survey. It is important to know what permissions you will need from your university before you start the outcome data collection process.

Find out if your university uses a particular data collection tool with other graduates. If so, you may want to use this tool or align your questions with it to permit comparisons with data on other graduates of the college.

Getting Responses

The National Postschool Outcomes Center developed a list of strategies for contacting former students and increasing response rates to outcome data surveys. We used this list in developing the following recommendations:

1. **PROVIDE PRE-NOTIFICATION:** While students are enrolled in the program, inform them you will be contacting them after they graduate.
2. **CREATE FAMILIARITY:** While students are actively involved in the program, explain why the upcoming survey is important and how it helps other students. Have them practice completing the survey before they leave the program so that they can ask you to clarify questions they may not understand.
3. **SHOW INTEREST:** When conducting the survey with former students, listen carefully and show genuine interest in their accomplishments and struggles that they encounter after graduation.
4. **PROVIDE INCENTIVES:** Give former students a reason to participate, such as a gift card, or provide information on employment or other opportunities they may be interested in.
5. **USE SOCIAL MEDIA:** This can be a particularly useful way to stay connected and check in with former students.
6. **STAY IN TOUCH:** Offer alumni engagement events or reunions, and send or feature alumni updates within college newsletters for former students.
7. **MAINTAIN A DATABASE OF CONTACT INFORMATION:** Regularly update contact information for former students.

When to Collect Data

Establish data collection timepoints. The NCC has found that once a year around the anniversary of the student's exit date works well. Previously, outcome data were collected at an additional timepoint, 90 days after the student's exit date, but this was found to be too burdensome for programs and raised concerns about the quality of outcomes achieved so soon after graduation when many students are just finding their feet in adult life.

The UP outcome survey is administered during the summer after program completion and then again one year after program completion. In the 2018–2019 academic year, the UP Program also conducted individual cumulative phone interviews with all program graduates and their family members since the program started in 2007. Consider what is important to you and feasible for your program.

How to Use Outcome Data

Once you have some outcome data collected, you'll need to think about what to analyze. You can look at outcomes for each cohort, or outcomes by particular experiences that students had in the program. For example, maybe some students participated in a particular job training program and you want to compare their experiences to students who did not participate in this program. You can also look at trends in outcomes over time (e.g., when students are one year out, two years out, and so on). By carefully reviewing data collected from students, you can identify what is working well and what areas of the program could use improvement.

As you begin to collect data, share it with students, families, college and university administration, legislators, policy makers, researchers, and other college programs. Make your data accessible to the public by writing a report or creating an infographic.

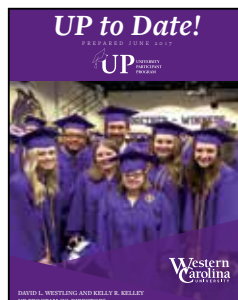
An example of how you can include outcome data in a report is the UP to Date report:

» www.dropbox.com/s/5y52uhnhere5ego/UPtoDatefinal.pdf?dl=0

An abbreviated factsheet version of the report:

» www.dropbox.com/s/70fjwmrla2w2oll/Fall2019UPFactSheet.pdf?dl=0

You could also write an article to include in your program newsletter or to share via social media.



Conclusion

Outcome data are critically important for providing evidence of the impact of your program. We hope that the ideas outlined in this guide will be useful for developing outcome measures, gathering data, and sharing that data with stakeholders.

Reference

National Post-School Outcomes Center. (n.d.). *Contacting hard-to-find youth: Strategies for the post-school survey*. Eugene, OR: Author. Retrieved from <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED559236.pdf>

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